



Off target: The Blue Tigers' inability to carve out substantial chances led to futile shots reeking of impatience.

NAGARA GOPAL

to do. Alaswad punished this indecisiveness by toe-poking the ball with the outside of his boot to beat Gurpreet Singh Sandhu at his near post.

Time for a fresh face between the sticks?

Vishal Kaith's exclusion was criticised by fans when Manolo announced his list of 26 probables for the Intercontinental Cup, considering the custodian's stellar season with the Mariners, where he played a crucial part (nine clean sheets and a 61 per cent save percentage in 25 matches) in helping them win the Indian Super League Shield.

Gurpreet, who captained India against Syria, has been a dependable presence between the sticks on countless occasions over the years. However, his recent performances for

both club and country have shown signs of rust, and the fact that he conceded two goals against Syria at his near post does not help his case. With Kaith consistently flourishing and Gurpreet's level deteriorating, one can only wonder how long Manolo will wait before he starts choosing Kaith as India's number one

keeper. The lack of preparation time and poor match fitness may absolve Manolo from much of the blame in his debut tournament as India's manager. However, time is short, and the areas for improvement are substantial as India gears up for important matches in the future with higher stakes.



Comprehensive win: The Syrian players celebrate with the trophy, after beating India 3-0. NAGARA GOPAL